



The Okefenokee Swamp

One of the largest swamps in North America, a diverse wetland ecosystem displaying remarkable biodiversity



Straddling the border between Georgia and Florida, the Okefenokee Swamp is a large, shallow wetland area lying in a basin that was once beneath the Atlantic Ocean. The swamp is dominated by peat-filled mires but also contains lakes, flooded prairies, and mixed woodlands. With an area of 685 square miles (1,770 square km), it is considered the largest “blackwater” swamp in North America. Although its waters are free of sediment, they are stained a dark color by tannins released by peat and decomposing vegetation.

Over the 7,000 years that the swamp has been forming, peat has collected to depths of more than 15 ft (4.5 m). In some areas, floating sections shudder when trodden on; translated from the Hitchiti language, Okefenokee means “water-shaking.” The swamp is drained by two rivers: the Suwannee River flows into the Gulf of Mexico, while the St. Marys River empties into the Atlantic.



Flourishing wildlife

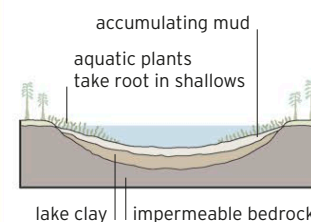
A great variety of animals and plants thrive in the Okefenokee Swamp’s mosaic of habitats. A haven for more than 230 bird species, including many wading birds and waterfowl, the swamp is well known for its abundance of amphibians and reptiles including alligators, snakes, and the alligator snapping turtle, the world’s largest freshwater turtle. It is also a key habitat for a population of Florida black bears and home to other mammals, including bobcats and otters. More than 600 plant species include the carnivorous sundews, bladderworts, and pitcher plants, which have developed their unusual diets to compensate for the nutrient-poor soils.

◁△ ACIDIC WATERS

The acidic waters and soils of the Okefenokee Swamp have led to unusual plant adaptations. The hooded pitcher plant is one of several varieties that capture and digest insects in their modified leaves.

HOW A MIRE FORMS

Mires (or bogs) form as flooded areas are filled in by sediment. Fen peat forms as mineral-rich groundwater prevents dead plant matter from decomposing. As the surface rises above the groundwater, mosses grow and their remains become bog peat.



WETLAND SUCCESSION



INTERMEDIATE STAGE



PEAT MIRE